

How to Clean a GMP Food Facility

Food plants are cleaned for auditors, allergen control, and product safety. Zones, drains, and discipline at the transition points are everything.

What Makes GMP Different

GMP (Good Manufacturing Practices) facilities answer to food safety audits, allergen programs, and pest control standards. The building is divided into zones, and the entire cleaning program is built around one idea: nothing crosses a zone line. Not a mop, not a bucket, not a glove.

Equipment & Chemicals

- HEPA backpack vacuum (dry sweeping airborne powders spreads allergens)
- Dual chamber mop buckets: one set for non production areas, a dedicated set for allergen and segregated zones
- Color coded microfiber and flat mop pads by zone, including orange for the production floor and yellow for allergen zones (see the Color Coding System)
- Dedicated drain brushes, one per zone, stored off the floor
- Hydrogen peroxide cleaner registered for food processing environments (EnvirOx H2O2 117), plus the client approved no rinse food contact sanitizer, verified with test strips at the start of every shift
- PPE: powder free nitrile gloves, safety glasses, hair net or bump cap, beard cover where required, and dedicated zone footwear or booties

The Nightly Process

- 1. Gear up:** PPE on and zone footwear changed before entering production.
- 2. Collect general waste only.** Allergen, rework, and product contact packaging waste streams stay separate per the client's posted program. Never compact production floor waste; sharp packaging and metal clips injure crews.
- 3. Disinfect non food contact surfaces.** Food contact surfaces are touched only if the scope includes them, and only with the approved no rinse sanitizer at the labeled dilution and contact time.
- 4. Treat spills** at the lines with heavy duty solution, deck brush, and the utility mop.
- 5. Vacuum floors** with the HEPA backpack. Move portable carts, pallets, and racks every night and clean under them. Never move fixed equipment without instruction.
- 6. Mop with the flat mop system** and light duty solution. In production zones, change the pad about every 150 to 200 sq ft, and always when crossing a zone line. Work from the far corner toward the zone exit, with the grain, in an S motion.
- 7. Scrub and flush drains nightly** with the zone's dedicated drain brush, then sanitize. Drains are the number one bacterial harborage point in any plant.

- 8. Clean non production areas** (lobby, break rooms, restrooms, locker and gowning areas, offices, and QA) with their own tools. Mop water never crosses zones.

Allergen & Segregated Zones

- Dedicated yellow tools only; they clean nothing else and launder separately.
- Extra PPE: safety glasses, booties or dedicated footwear, face mask, and hair and beard cover. Fresh gloves on entry, and again every time you step out and return.
- Clean the segregated zone last, then remove PPE and change gloves before touching any other area.

First Time Takeover: Baked On Residue

New accounts usually come with product residue (sugar, protein, starch, fat, or flour) baked into corners, under lines, and around drains:

1. Scrape with a plastic or non marking scraper.
2. Vacuum the loose residue; never dry sweep it.
3. Apply hot water, let it dwell, then scrub with minimal water for a sanding effect.
4. Pick up the slurry, then scrub, flush, and sanitize every drain.

Crew Training Checklist

- ☐ Spill response and product spill clean up
- ☐ Allergen segregation and cross contamination prevention
- ☐ Color coded tool zoning, and food contact vs. non food contact surfaces
- ☐ Sanitizer dilution, contact time, and test strip verification
- ☐ Glove change protocol between zones and after breaks
- ☐ Drain cleaning and bacterial harborage prevention
- ☐ Pest sighting reporting, and segregated waste stream handling

End of Shift

Rinse and sanitize buckets, brushes, and squeegees, invert them to air dry, and store everything off the floor. Wet storage is the fastest way to grow bacteria on your own tools. Machine wash microfiber weekly, with allergen zone items washed separately.